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DTC MBA: Not all customers are equal – here's how to rank them

1 mensagem

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Not all customers are equal – how to rank them

When you think about it, the idea that inside Shopify, a one-time discount shopper and a multi-year VIP both show up under the same label: “customer” is not just crazy, but operationally, it's insane.

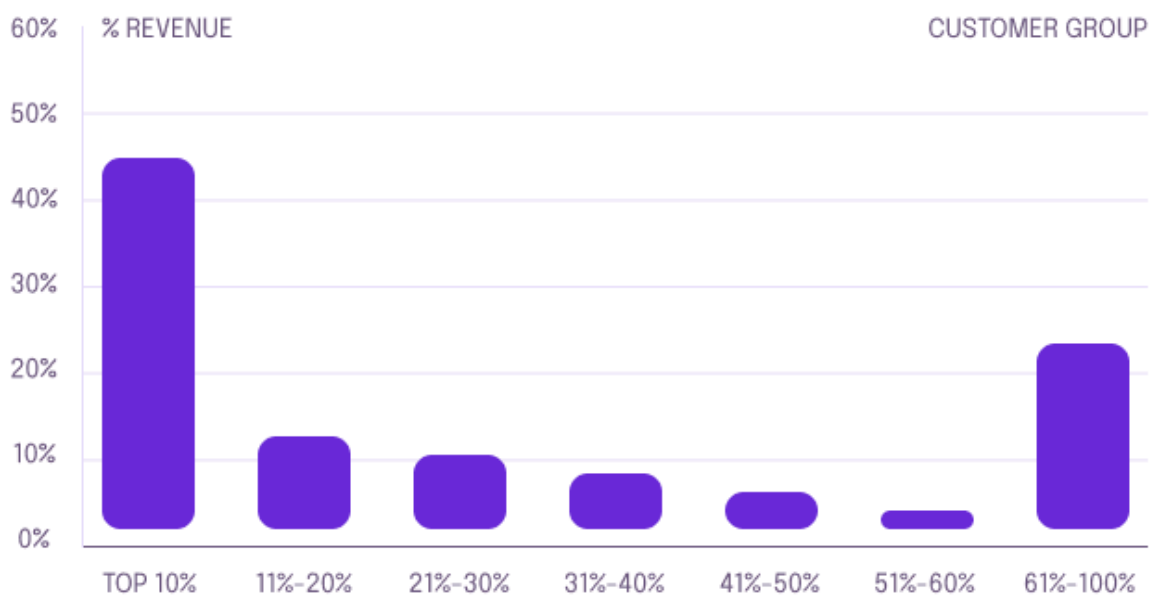
That's why, In this email, I'll want to prioritize walking you through RFM – Recency, Frequency, Monetary – by far the simplest way to turn your messy customer list into a clear value map.

You'll see how to identify true Top Customers, High Potentials, small buyers and the dead weight that quietly eats your marketing budget. I promise, once you've seen your file through this lens, it becomes very hard to go back to “everyone gets the same newsletter.”

Value map > Customer list

Percentile Analysis

\$ contribution by customer percentile



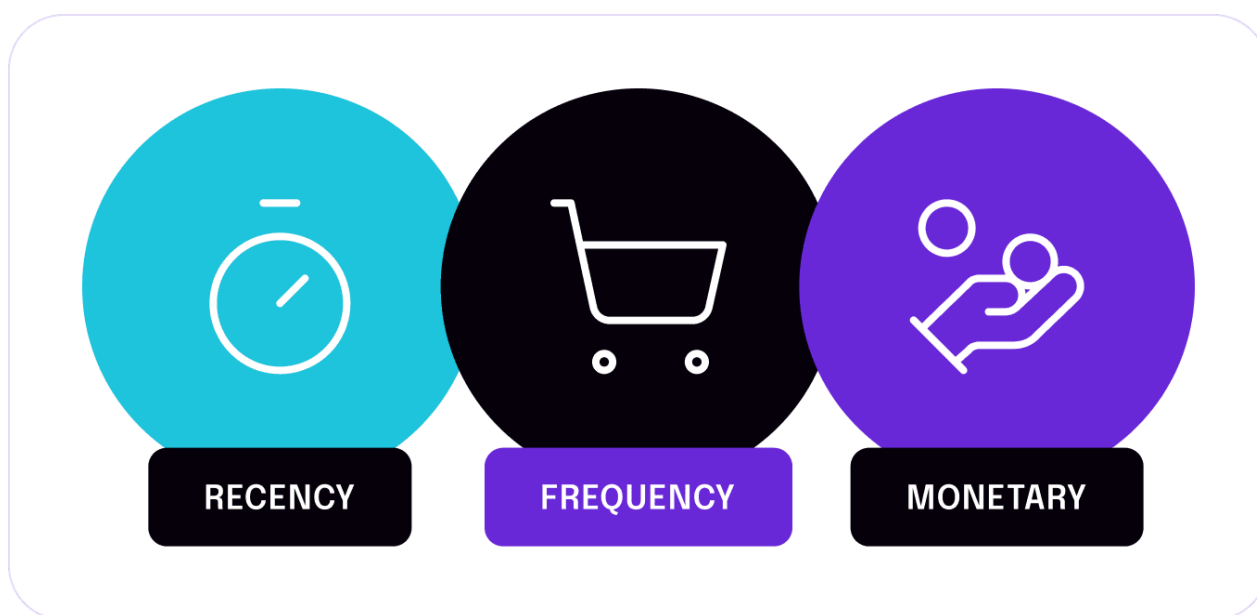
In almost every seven, eight, or nine-figure brand I've seen, the customer file looks like the above chart. A small group of customers (often 1–10%) drive a huge share of the revenue and profit. There is a broad middle that is healthy but not critical and a VERY long tail of one-time, low-value, heavily discounted buyers.

By treating these groups the same in your CRM, ads and services, you are literally misallocating capital every single day and you end up doing one or all of the following:

- **Overspending** on dead or low-value segments
- **Under-investing** in the people who are actually funding your P&L
- **No clear prioritization** for “who deserves what”

RFM is the cleanest way to fix this common problem as It gives you a simple, numerical way to answer the core question: Who actually matters in my customer file?

RFM (In operator terms)



At its core, RFM gives every customer a numerical score on three data points which then automatically ranks your customer base depending on how where they fit in a scoring framework: At its core, RFM scores every customer on three things:

- **Recency (R):** How long ago did they last buy?
 - High R = they're active in the relationship
 - Low R = they're drifting or gone
- **Frequency (F):** How many orders have they placed?
 - High F = habit, routine, trust
 - Low F = trial, occasional, or one-and-done
- **Monetary (M):** How much have they spent in total?

- High M = meaningful contribution to revenue
- Low M = noise, especially after COGS and discounts

Perfect precision is not needed to start ranking your customers with RFM. In fact, a simple 1–5 scale for each metric is usually best and easily separates your whales from your minnows.

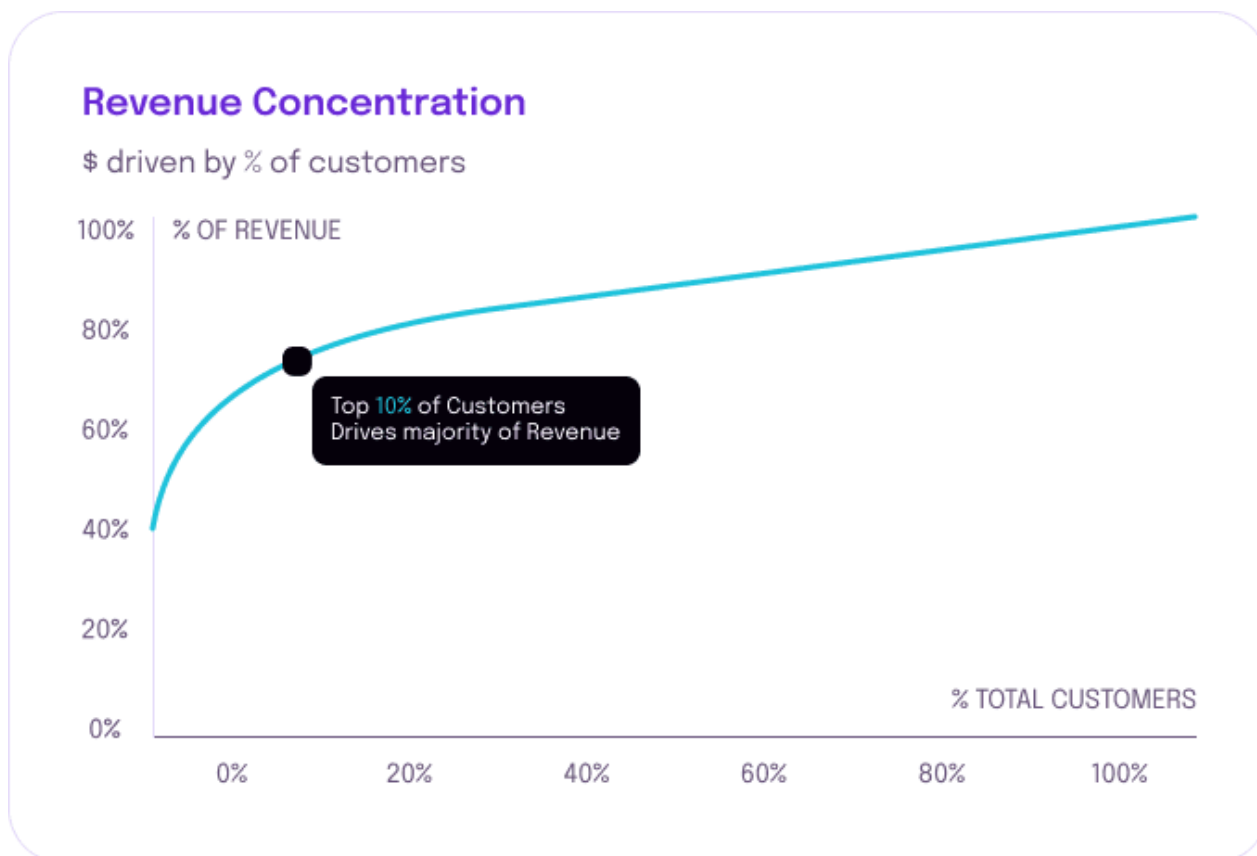
Go from RFM scores, to real segments

Once you have R, F and M, you can group customers into segments that actually mean something commercially. For example:

- **Top Customers** – Very recent, very frequent, high spend. These are your whales. They drive contribution margin and fund experiments.
- **High Potentials** – Recent, a few orders, and decent spend. These are potential “next generation” of Top Customers if you treat them right.
- **Loyal Middle** – Regular customers with solid but not crazy spend. Reliable, profitable, should be kept happy but don't need concierge treatment.
- **Bargain Hunters / Promo-Only** – Frequent but low spend, often discount-led. Good for controlled volume, bad if they dominate your file.
- **At Risk / Fading** – Good Frequency (F) and Monetary (M), but recency (R) is low. This is your highest-leverage retention target.
- **Low-Value One-Timers** – Low recency (R), low frequency (F), low monetary (M). This is a group you can stop obsessing over.

You can slice this more finely if you want, but even 4–6 clear segments will radically change how you think about your customer base through a **value map** compared to a list.

How skewed your file really is



If you are a visual person, all you need to do is overlay RFM with concentration, then picture becomes very clear, very fast. The Top Customers segment (maybe 1–10% of your file) often contributes 30–60% of revenue. High Potentials + Loyal Middle add another large chunk of stable revenue (your top 20% of customers).

Then, an entire long tail of one-timers, bargain hunters and low M-score customers contributes surprisingly little profit once you subtract COGS and discounts. From a CEO/CMO perspective, this leads to some uncomfortable but important truths:

- Losing one Top Customer can hurt more than losing 100 one-timers.
- Focusing retention efforts on low-value segments is often a waste.
- Over-discounting to keep bargain hunters “active” can actively damage your economics.

If you want to go deeper into how extreme this skew can be, this is where the customer concentration lens becomes really powerful.

How RFM changes what you actually do

Once you have RFM and usable segments, almost everything in your growth strategy gets sharper and more executable. From a channel perspective, here are some practical ways in which it will drive your output:

Email/SMS:

- Top Customers → Plan fewer, more personal, and value-dense messages. Prioritize access, and early drops
- High Potentials → Prioritize onboarding, product education, smart cross-sells to increase F and M
- Bargain Hunters → Ringfenced promo flows with clear guardrails
- Low-Value One-Timers → Plan a light touch or start to sunset; don't burn budget and expend valuable time and resources here.

Paid media:

- Build lookalikes from Top + High Potential segments, not from “all purchasers” so channels are learning from your best customers.
- Exclude low-M segments from retargeting where possible

CX & Ops:

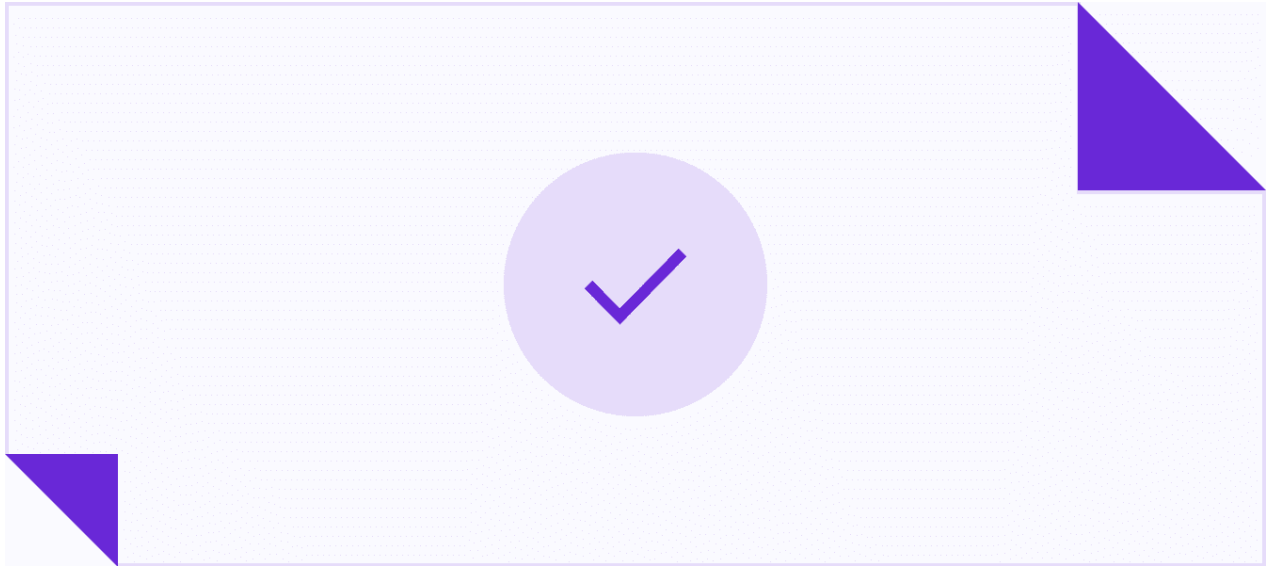
- Flag Top Customers in support systems – create different SLAs and different escalation rules for this group.
- Treat At-Risk high RFM customers as “save at all costs” cases, not generic tickets

Product & Promotions:

- See which products over-index in Top & High Potential segments and promote those more to generate better outcomes.
- Spot products that mostly attract low-M, discount-only buyers and use carefully or demote them in your plans.

RFM is not a reporting toy. It's a routing layer for money, attention and effort.

Next up: we'll connect this to cohorts – so you're not just seeing who matters today, but whether your new customers are on track to become the kind of customers you actually want more of. Start writing your email content here...



What I'd have my team do this week

You don't need a six-month project to start getting value from this. I'd ask my team for three simple outputs:

1. **Current RFM segmentation of the entire customer file** - How many customers in each key segment? (Top, High Potential, Loyal Middle, Bargain Hunters, At Risk, Low-Value One-Timers)
2. **Revenue and contribution margin by segment** - What % of revenue and CM1 comes from Top + High Potential vs the rest? How much are we spending (media, discounts, CX effort) on each group?
3. **One concrete action per high-value segment** - What are we going to do differently for Top Customers? How are we going to accelerate High Potentials into Top? How are we going to stop over-servicing low-value segments?

Reach out to me if your team does not have what they need to look at your your customer base this way.

Readers Note: Hit reply and tell me (roughly): Whether you already use RFM (yes/no). Also, your best guess at what % of revenue your top 10% of customers generate.

Update your email preferences or unsubscribe [here](#)

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